ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Cleft sentences

Cleft sentences do not normally add a new fact. They reorganise a message so the reader knows exactly which person, time, place or result carries the contrast.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Control which information the speaker presents as contrast or focus.

Divide one proposition into two clauses to control focus: It was Maya who found the error; What we need is more time.

MODEL

Maya found the error. -> It was Maya who found the error.

it + be + focus + relative clause | what-clause + be + focus

6 GUIDED STAGES · 29 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Identify the element that deserves contrastive focus.

OUTCOME 2

02

Build natural it-clefts, what-clefts and all-clefts.

OUTCOME 3

03

Use agreement and relative clauses accurately without redundant pronouns.

Build meaning before form

Divide one proposition into two clauses to control focus: It was Maya who found the error; What we need is more time.

How an it-cleft creates contrast

In It was Thursday that we met, the focused constituent appears between be and the relative clause. The sentence naturally answers an implicit contrast such as Thursday, not Wednesday.

The focused element can be a person, object, time, place or prepositional phrase. The underlying proposition remains the same; its information structure changes.

Maya found the error.	It was Maya who found the error.
We met on Friday.	It was on Friday that we met.

What-clefts present needs and results

What the team needs is clearer guidance prepares the reader for new information after be. This pattern is common in explanations, meetings and argumentative writing.

The what-clause functions as a nominal subject. Agreement normally follows the focused complement, although singular is common when the complement is treated as one idea.

Neutral statement	Cleft sentence
We need a decision.	What we need is a decision.
Ana solved the issue.	It was Ana who solved the issue.

Focus must answer an implicit question

A natural cleft responds to an information gap: who did it, when did it happen, where did it happen, or what is needed? Without that contrast, the structure can sound heavy.

Use prosody in speech and punctuation in writing to support the intended focus; grammar alone cannot rescue an unclear contrast.

From emphasis to cohesion

Clefts can connect a paragraph by turning known material into the frame and placing the important new point at the end. That end-focus makes dense explanations easier to process.

Vary clefts with neutral clauses. Repetition reduces their rhetorical force and can make prose sound artificially dramatic.

Reason through the pattern

The frame moves the spotlight to a person, time, place or result without changing the core fact. First recover the neutral proposition, then identify the intended contrast.

01	02	03	04	05	06	07
it	be	focus	relative clause	what-clause	be	focus

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Use an it-cleft for a specific contrast of person, time, place or object.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Use a what-cleft to foreground an action, need or result.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Check agreement and remove any repeated pronoun from the relative clause.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Type	Structure	Example
it-cleft	it + be + focus + relative	It was Ana who called.
what-cleft	what + clause + be + focus	What I need is a break.
all-cleft	all + clause + be + focus	All we need is time.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

Maya found the error.	It was Maya who...
We need clarity.	What we need is...
We met on Friday.	It was on Friday that...

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Repeating a pronoun inside the relative clause.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using what when the focus is a specific person.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Forcing a cleft into a sentence with no meaningful contrast.

Recognition in context

Choose the form that completes each situation naturally.

A1 · CONTEXT 1

___ Daniel who approved the final version.

OPTIONS It was · What was · There was · That was what

A2 · CONTEXT 2

___ more reliable evidence.

OPTIONS What we need is · It we need that · What do we need is · It is need

A3 · CONTEXT 3

It was in May ___ the policy changed.

OPTIONS that · what · where it · which it

A4 · CONTEXT 4

All I wanted ___ a clear answer.

OPTIONS was · were · it was · that

A5 · CONTEXT 5

What surprised me most ___ her calm response.

OPTIONS was · were · did · it

A6 · CONTEXT 6

It was at the station ___ we first met.

OPTIONS that · what · which it · where did

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Two connected decisions

Resolve two connected choices within the same context.

B1 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 1

It _____ the budget that caused the delay; what we lacked _____ enough staff.

OPTIONS Gap 1: was / were / did · Gap 2: was / were / it was

B2 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 2

It _____ not the manager but her assistant who called. What they wanted _____ an immediate reply.

OPTIONS Gap 1: was / were / did · Gap 2: was / were / that

B3 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 3

It _____ only after midnight that the server recovered. All we could do _____ wait.

OPTIONS Gap 1: was / were / had · Gap 2: was / were / did

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided text

Maintain the target structure throughout a complete text.

C1 · GUIDED APPLICATION

It _____ the final test that revealed the fault. What the engineers had overlooked _____ a minor connection. It _____ Priya who noticed the pattern, but what solved the problem _____ a complete restart. All the client wanted _____ a reliable explanation.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

did · it · that · was · were

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open text

Supply every form without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT APPLICATION

Lena found the key. (Lena) -> _____. We need a practical solution. -> _____. The error occurred during upload. (during upload) -> _____. I only asked for honesty. -> _____. The lack of data worried us. -> _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled production

Transform the idea without changing its meaning.

E1 · CONTROLLED TASK 1

Emphasise Sam: Sam changed the schedule.

_____
_____

E2 · CONTROLLED TASK 2

Write an original Cleft sentences response for context 2. Include what we need is.

_____
_____

E3 · CONTROLLED TASK 3

Write an original Cleft sentences response for context 3. Include it was in bogotá that, it was in bogota that.

_____
_____

E4 · CONTROLLED TASK 4

Correct: It was Ana who she sent the file.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative mission

Use the structure in original responses and realistic situations.

F1 · COMMUNICATION TASK 1

Write an original Cleft sentences response for context 1. Include what we recommend is.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · COMMUNICATION TASK 2

Write an original Cleft sentences response for context 2. Include it was not, it was.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · COMMUNICATION TASK 3

Write an original Cleft sentences response for context 3. Include what, it was.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: it-cleft.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: what-cleft.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: focus.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: agreement.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

It was

Use “It was”. Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence.

A2

What we need is

Use “What we need is”. Use an it-cleft for a specific contrast of person, time, place or object.

A3

that

Use “that”. Use a what-cleft to foreground an action, need or result.

A4

was

Use “was”. Check agreement and remove any repeated pronoun from the relative clause.

A5

was

Use “was”. Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence.

A6

that

Use “that”. Use an it-cleft for a specific contrast of person, time, place or object.

Two connected decisions

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

was / was

Use “was”. Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence. Use “was”. Use an it-cleft for a specific contrast of person, time, place or object.

B2

was / was

Use “was”. Use an it-cleft for a specific contrast of person, time, place or object. Use “was”. Use a what-cleft to foreground an action, need or result.

B3

was / was

Use “was”. Use a what-cleft to foreground an action, need or result. Use “was”. Check agreement and remove any repeated pronoun from the relative clause.

Guided text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

was

Use “was”. Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence.

C2

was

Use “was”. Use an it-cleft for a specific contrast of person, time, place or object.

C3

was

Use “was”. Use a what-cleft to foreground an action, need or result.

C4

was

Use “was”. Check agreement and remove any repeated pronoun from the relative clause.

C5

was

Use “was”. Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence.

Open text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

It was Lena who found the key

Use “It was Lena who found the key”. Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence.

D2

What we need is a practical solution

Use “What we need is a practical solution”. Use an it-cleft for a specific contrast of person, time, place or object.

D3

It was during upload that the error occurred

Use “It was during upload that the error occurred”. Use a what-cleft to foreground an action, need or result.

D4

All I asked for was honesty

Use “All I asked for was honesty”. Check agreement and remove any repeated pronoun from the relative clause.

D5

What worried us was the lack of data

Use “What worried us was the lack of data”. Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence.

Controlled production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

It was Sam who changed the schedule.

Use “It was Sam who changed the schedule.”. Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence.

E2

What we need is more time.

Use “What we need is more time.”. Use an it-cleft for a specific contrast of person, time, place or object.

E3

It was in Bogotá that we met.

Use “It was in Bogotá that we met.”. Use a what-cleft to foreground an action, need or result.

E4

It was Ana who sent the file.

Use “It was Ana who sent the file.”. Check agreement and remove any repeated pronoun from the relative clause.

Communicative mission

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

What we recommend is a gradual rollout.

The model combines accurate Cleft sentences with a clear purpose. Choose the element that needs emphasis before changing the sentence.

F2

It was not the price that changed; it was the delivery date.

The model combines accurate Cleft sentences with a clear purpose. Use an it-cleft for a specific contrast of person, time, place or object.

F3

What the team needs is direction. It was the new manager who finally provided it.

The model combines accurate Cleft sentences with a clear purpose. Use a what-cleft to foreground an action, need or result.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____